

- RAG Learning

3B.4 Power and Developments

Politics — Edexcel (9PL0) — Component 3B: Global Politics — spec topic 5: Power and developments

Exam Tip: Component 3 has two routes. This is **3B (Global Politics)**; the alternative is **3A (Comparative Politics: USA)**. You sit one, never both.

This topic covers the distribution of power in the international system and how it has changed. It supplies the raw material for most Section C essays on this route, because almost every question about global governance reduces to a question about who has power and what they do with it.

Hard power — military or economic coercion to change another actor's behaviour.

Soft power — obtaining preferred outcomes through attraction, resting on culture, values and perceived legitimacy.

Smart power — combining hard and soft instruments in a coherent strategy.

Structural power — the ability to shape the frameworks within which others operate.

Polarity — how power is distributed among the major states.

Hegemon — a state with sufficient preponderance to set and underwrite the rules of the order.

Superpower — a state with global military reach, economic weight, and ideological and cultural influence.

Failed state — one that can no longer perform the basic functions of government.

Rogue state — a state held to disregard international norms.

Emerging power — a state whose relative capability is rising significantly.

Human Development Index — composite measure of life expectancy, education and income.

1. Types of power

Type	Instruments	Limits
Hard	Armed force, threat of force, sanctions, economic inducement	Expensive; may fail to produce political outcomes — Afghanistan and Iraq
Soft	Culture, political values, foreign policy perceived as legitimate, education, media	Cannot be directed at will; works slowly; rarely shifts vital interests; easily destroyed by conduct
Smart	Coherent combination of the two	Requires strategic coordination most states struggle to sustain
Structural	Setting rules, standards, the reserve currency, technological norms	Concentrated in very few states; slow to build, slow to lose

Nye's point about soft power is often misunderstood: its effect is to make others *willing* rather than coerced, so it appears as an absence of resistance rather than as a visible outcome. That makes it real but very hard to measure, which is its central analytical weakness.

2. Polarity

System	Description	Stability argument
Unipolar	One preponderant state — the US after 1991	Stable if the hegemon underwrites the order; invites balancing and overreach
Bipolar	Two dominant blocs — the Cold War	Realists argue it is most stable: a clear, calculable adversary reduces miscalculation
Multipolar	Several comparable powers — Europe before 1914	More flexible balancing, but shifting alignments increase uncertainty and the risk of miscalculation

Is the system now multipolar?

For: China's economic scale and sustained military modernisation; a reassertive Russia willing to use force; regional powers — India, Brazil, Turkey, Saudi Arabia — acting with increasing autonomy and declining to align, as responses to the war in Ukraine illustrated; relative American decline in share of global output.

Against: American military reach remains unmatched; the dollar's role as the reserve currency gives Washington financial leverage no rival possesses; its alliance network has no equivalent; it retains leadership in the technologies that matter most.

The judgement: power is now distributed *unevenly across dimensions* — the system is economically multipolar, militarily closer to unipolar, and institutionally somewhere between. No single label fits, and saying so is a better answer than choosing one.

3. The significance of states

- **Superpowers** — able to project power globally across every dimension: military (including nuclear and naval reach), economic, political and cultural. The US and USSR were the Cold War superpowers; the US is the only one now, and whether China has become one is debated — it matches the US economically but lacks comparable global military reach and alliances.
- **Great powers** — the P5, plus economically significant states without permanent seats (Germany, Japan, India).
- **Emerging powers** — BRICS (originally Brazil, Russia, India, China, South Africa; enlarged from 2024 to include Egypt, Ethiopia, Iran, the UAE and Indonesia) and others; notable for building *parallel* institutions such as the AIIB and the New Development Bank rather than attacking existing ones.
- **Middle powers** — influence through diplomacy, coalition-building and specialisation.
- **Failed and fragile states** — generate consequences that cross borders.

Why rising powers have not overturned the order

They benefited from the trade and financial order they inherited, so they press for greater voice *within* institutions while building parallel ones, rather than confronting the order directly. That is an important corrective to simple power-transition narratives, and it is evidence for the liberal claim that institutions socialise as well as constrain.

4. Systems of government and development

	Democratic	Semi-democratic	Non-democratic	Autocratic
Selection	Free, competitive multi-party elections	Elections held, but tilted by media control and pressure on opponents	Elections absent or non-competitive; rule by a party or elite	Power held by a single ruler or ruling family
Accountability	Removable government; independent media and courts	Partial — courts and media constrained	Limited or absent	Absent
Examples	UK, Germany, Japan	Turkey, Singapore	China (one-party state)	North Korea, Saudi Arabia
Claimed advantage	Legitimacy, information flow, self-correction	Stability with a degree of popular consent	Decisiveness, long-term planning, insulation from short-term pressure	Speed of decision

Failed states (Somalia, Libya after 2011) cannot control their territory or provide basic services, and export instability through conflict, refugees and terrorism. **Rogue states** (North Korea and Iran are the usual examples) are held to defy international norms — pursuing weapons of mass destruction, sponsoring terrorism or ignoring international law. The label is contested: it is applied chiefly by the US and its allies, rarely to their own partners, and critics argue it is a political judgement rather than a neutral category.

Democratisation and its reversal

The "third wave" from the 1970s saw a large expansion in the number of electoral democracies. It has stalled and partly reversed, and the mechanism matters: contemporary democratic decline rarely takes the form of a coup. Elected leaders weaken courts, curtail media independence, alter electoral

rules and hollow out institutions *while retaining elections* — which makes the process gradual, deniable and difficult to resist.

Contributing factors: the credibility of authoritarian alternatives delivering growth; the record of imposed democratisation in Iraq and Afghanistan; performance failures in established democracies after 2008; and reduced external pressure, since alternative sources of finance allow authoritarian governments to avoid democratic conditionality.

Development

Measured by GDP per capita, the **HDI** (life expectancy, education, income) and the Sustainable Development Goals. The examinable debate is whether development requires democracy: China's sustained growth is the standard counter-example, and it weakens the modernisation assumption that economic development produces democratisation.

5. Evaluation

Does economic interdependence prevent conflict?

Liberal claim	Realist reply
War between integrated economies imposes severe costs, raising the threshold for force	Britain and Germany were each other's major trading partners before 1914
Trade creates constituencies with an interest in peace	Dependence creates vulnerability: energy supply and export controls are coercive instruments
Institutions supply channels for managing disputes	Security concerns override economic cost — the cost of the Ukraine war to Russia was foreseeable and did not deter
It reduces the <i>probability</i> of conflict at the margin	Major powers are now deliberately decoupling in strategic sectors, reversing the mechanism

Is power becoming harder to measure?

Yes, for three compounding reasons: power is distributed unevenly across dimensions; new domains — cyber capability, supply chain leverage, standard-setting, information influence — do not reduce to conventional metrics; and power is *relational*, so the capacity to achieve one objective does not transfer to another. Overwhelming military superiority did not deliver American objectives in Afghanistan. If power is the ability to produce intended outcomes, it can only be assessed after the event and against a specific objective — which is why confident claims about polarity should be treated sceptically.

Quick recall

- Hard / soft / smart / structural power; Nye coined soft and smart
- Superpower (US; USSR in the Cold War; China debated) / great / emerging powers
- Democratic, semi-democratic, non-democratic, autocratic states; failed (Somalia, Libya) and rogue (North Korea, Iran) states
- Unipolar, bipolar, multipolar — realists generally argue bipolarity is most stable
- The system is economically multipolar, militarily closer to unipolar — no single label fits
- Emerging powers build parallel institutions (the BRICS NDB, the China-led AIIB) rather than attacking existing ones
- Democratic decline now happens through elected leaders hollowing out institutions, not coups
- HDI = life expectancy + education + income
- Pre-1914 interdependence is the standard case against the liberal peace claim
- Power is relational: military superiority did not deliver outcomes in Afghanistan